6.3 Adding and subtracting: activities

← Unit overview

1. Estimate the shopping

You need: a supermarket receipt or folder, or a real shopping trip.

Before paying, round each price to the nearest euro and keep a running estimate. Compare with the real total at the till. Next time, try estimating to the nearest €10 for a big shop.

For bigger numbers: use a folder from an electronics or furniture shop. "A sofa for €689 and a table for €245. About how much together?" (About €700 + €200 = €900.)

Talk about it: "Was your estimate too high or too low? Why do you think?"

2. Money columns

You need: paper slips labelled €100, €10 and €1 (about 20 of each), and a large sheet of paper with three columns: H, T, E.

1. **Adding:** build 487 and 235 in the columns. Push them together. "Do we have 10 or more of anything?" Swap ten €1 slips for one €10 slip and move it to the T column. Then swap ten €10 slips for a €100. That's exactly what the small carried 1 means in *cijferend*.
2. **Subtracting:** build €432 and try to pay €263. "We need 3 single euros but only have 2. What can we do?" Swap a €10 for ten €1s. Continue. That's *inwisselen*.
3. Let him be the banker who does the swapping.

Talk about it: "When do you need to swap? When don't you?"

3. Bike-trip planner

You need: a map, a cycle route planner app, paper.

Plan a pretend (or real!) bike holiday over a few days. Find the distance for each day. Add them up: how far altogether? "We want to ride 150 km in total. We've done 47 and 58. How far is left?"

Talk about it: "Which is easier for you here: adding up the days, or working out what's left? Why?"

4. Spot the mistake

You need: paper.

You (the parent) do three written sums, with one mistake on purpose. A typical one: 432 − 263 = 231 (taking the smaller digit from the bigger one). He is the teacher: find the mistake and explain it to you. Then you make a mistake for him to check in the next session too.

This is powerful for anxious children: finding someone *else's* mistake is safe, and it shows that mistakes are normal and fixable.

Talk about it: "How did you know it was wrong? Did the estimate help?"

5. Change at the till

You need: coins and notes (real or play), price labels.

Set up a shop. Prices are whole euros at first (€37, €64), later with cents. He's the shopkeeper. The customer pays with a €50 or €100 note. He works out the change by **counting up** (the way many shopkeepers do): €64 to €70 is €6, €70 to €100 is €30, so the change is €36.

Counting up is a perfectly good subtraction strategy (*aanvullen*). Point it out.

Talk about it: "Is counting up or taking away easier for €100 − €64? And for €100 − €2?"

Conversation prompts (any time)

- "Is 1 000 − 999 hard? Why not, even though the numbers are big?"
- "What's a sum where estimating would be enough? Where you need the exact answer?"
- "Can you make up a subtraction where you need to exchange twice?"
- "What's your favourite way to check a subtraction?"